▼ VIEWPOINT

INDIA'S CHINESE PUZZLE

India-China relations have broken through the deep chill, but their future course depends on ongoing geopolitical shifts



BY SHYAM SARAN

India-China relations are in a slow crawl towards a new equilibrium as they respond to a new situation on their contested border and a vastly transformed geopolitical terrain. The Peace and Tranquility agreement of 1993, and subsequent confidence-building measures which were built on it, helped keep the border stable and peaceful for the past three decades. This came to an end with the aggressive Chinese military manoeuvres in eastern Ladakh in 2022. Thanks to the major improvements in border infrastructure by India since 2004, Indian armed forces were able to quickly deploy a comparable force to prevent Chinese ingress into Indian territory. While disengagement of forces has taken place in some segments of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) and patrolling has resumed in other segments, the redeployment of forces back to their base locations inland has not taken place. Until this is achieved, one cannot say that the situation has returned to status quo ante.

Enough progress was achieved in the several rounds of bilateral negotiations between their military and diplomatic personnel to enable a summit meeting between PM Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping at Kazan, Russia, on October 23, 2024, on the sidelines of the BRICS summit. The leaders, meeting bilaterally after a gap of nearly five years, agreed to resume engagement at the levels of their senior officials, their special representatives and foreign ministers. Pilgrimage to Kailash Mansarovar, border trade through Nathu La pass, direct flights and the exchange of media personnel are to follow. This is still far short of the scale of exchanges which the two countries had developed over several years.



Illustration by RAJ VERMA

BEIJING'S SUPPORT FOR PAKISTAN'S CALL FOR AN INDEPENDENT PROBE INTO PAHALGAM MAY RETARD THE RESTORATION OF INDIA-CHINA TIES

The ongoing tensions between India and Pakistan in the aftermath of the terrorist outrage in Pahalgam are a further complicating factor. China has supported Pakistan's proposal for an independent investigation which India rejects and this may retard the restoration of India-China ties.

While India has downgraded its political and security relations with China, it has been unable to put constraints on a still expanding economic and commercial relationship. This is not surprising, considering that China is an integral part of all key global supply and value chains. The dependence on China for critical components and intermediates as well as finished products cannot be reduced overnight. This creates an economic and security vulnerability for India.

The prospects for India-China relations will be influenced by the trajectory of recent geopolitical shifts in the wake of US President Donald Trump's radical domestic and external policies. Trump speaks both about a relentless trade war with China and, at the same time, doing a "grand bargain" with it. He appears to be pulling back from US external commitments, but is this to free up resources to retain and even enhance its presence in the Indo-Pacific? Or is he likely to concede a Chinese sphere of influence in Asia while claiming dominance over the Americas, and adjacent territories such as Greenland, for the US? India's posture towards China will be determined accordingly, but long-standing rejection of Chinese hegemony and a preference for a multipolar Asia—and world—will not change. Even if there are positive but tactical improvements in relations, they will in essence remain adversarial. ■

Shyam Saran *is a former foreign secretary*